

Sensory Overload & Recovery Plan

Original worksheet by Sophia Cohon, PhD

Notice load, choose changes, and make room for recovery.

Where am I right now? Point or choose.

☐ Room to spare I can take things in.	☐ Load rising I need a change.	☐ Too much Reduce input now.	☐ Recovering Give me time.
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My first sign of overload

Body needs to check: pain, hunger, tiredness...

What is adding load? What can change?

Difficult input

☐ Sound	☐ Light
☐ Touch / crowding	☐ Too many words
☐ Change / surprise	☐ Too much to do



Support I choose

☐ Quieter place	☐ Lower light
☐ More space	☐ Fewer words
☐ Show what comes next	☐ Pause or simplify



Signal What I can say, show, or point to 	→	Reduce Where I can go / what can stop 	→	Recover What helps, by my choice
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Please help me by...

☐ Using fewer words	☐ Giving me space	☐ Offering my communication tool	☐ Asking before touch
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I may be ready when...

First manageable step back

Keep helpful supports available. Discuss what happened after recovery, when the person can participate.

Plan this together before overload

Ask the person what overload feels like, how they communicate, and which supports they want. A person may need different supports on different days.

What helps recovery?

What makes recovery harder?

Who needs to know the pause signal, safe place, and support plan?

For helpers

- Reduce sound, crowding, demands, and unnecessary talking when those are adding load.
- Allow communication through speech, writing, pointing, or a device. Avoid demanding eye contact, explanations, or an apology during overload.
- Offer supports the person has chosen. Do not force touch, pressure, weighted items, or other sensory input.

Look beyond sensory input. Pain, illness, hunger, sleep, medication effects, trauma cues, and immediate danger may also matter. New or concerning symptoms need appropriate assessment. This sheet does not determine the cause of distress.

Review when ready

What helped us reduce the load?

What will we change next time?

About this worksheet. This original planning tool summarizes the guidance linked below. It is not a validated assessment or a copy of an external worksheet. Guidance checked September 29, 2026.

- [National Autistic Society: autism and sensory processing](#)
- [National Autistic Society: understanding and responding to meltdowns](#)